Taiwan, took maritime territory when possible, and built and militarized island bases in the South China Sea during the 2010s. Ultimately, it was aggressive Chinese actions on September 8–9, 2025, that led to the accidents which precipitated conflict.

Second, all analysts and historians recognized the crucial role of contingency in the outbreak of hostilities. Because US and Chinese ships and planes were increasingly in proximity to each other, accidents were more likely to happen, especially given the aggressive nature of Chinese ship drivers and pilots. The 2001 EP-3E incident was a harbinger of the kind of accident that could throw relations into a tailspin. As it turned out, the two unconnected incidents on September 8 were enough to tip the balance toward conflict, given high tensions and the lack of deconfliction between US and PLA forces in the skies and on the sea. In short, the two nations stumbled into a war neither wanted.

In addition, later on in the conflict, the disabling of the *Liaoning* by a JMSDF attack submarine on September 22 introduced a wild card into combat operations. The Chinese retaliatory attack on the USS *Gerald Ford* had the potential to cause the war to spiral out of control, leading to US attacks on mainland missile launch sites, communications nodes, ports, airfields, and the like. These, in turn, would almost certainly have resulted in Chinese counterattacks on US territory, including Guam and Hawaii, and possibly San Diego. The next step might well have been limited nuclear exchanges (this will be discussed further in the fifth point, below).

Third, probably because the two came into armed conflict accidentally, rather than through intent on either side, neither was sure just how far hostilities would develop, nor how far they themselves wanted to go. Rather than activating full war plans, each side initially concentrated on the narrow site of the accidents, combining rescue operations with attempts to clear the other country's forces from the vicinity. Washington hoped that minimum deterrence would initially suffice to send signals to Beijing that US forces would not surrender its position in eastern Asian waters without a fight. For its part, Beijing, though committed to achieving domination in Asia's seas, hesitated to commit to a horizontal